

The Ethics of Remembering vs. Forgetting:

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Abstract

This essay examines the philosophical and political tensions between collective remembering and institutionalised forgetting, using the Jeju April Third Incident (4.3 사건) as its primary case study. Situated within the broader discourse of transitional justice and memory ethics, the essay argues that deliberate amnesia imposed by state power constitutes not merely a historiographical failure but an ethical transgression against the dead, the surviving, and the civic community. Drawing upon scholarship from Paul Ricoeur, Aleida Assmann, and Henry Rousso, alongside empirical data from the Jeju 4.3 Research Institute and official government investigations, the essay contends that the belated acknowledgment of the Jeju massacre illuminates the moral stakes inherent in all politics of memory.

I. Introduction: The Moral Architecture of Memory

In his monumental work *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2004), Paul Ricoeur distinguished between two fundamentally different modalities of forgetting: the forgetting that is wrought by the erasure of traces, and the forgetting that is “reserved”—a latent preservation kept at the threshold of recollection, awaiting the conditions of its return. The Jeju April Third Incident (4.3 사건) belongs emphatically to the first category. What unfolded on the island of Jeju between April 3, 1948, and September 21, 1954, was not merely suppressed: it was actively unmade, its victims unnamed, its perpetrators shielded by the architecture of Cold War ideology and an authoritarian state’s self-serving historiography. That this silence persisted for nearly half a century renders the ethical question of memory not merely academic but urgently practical.

The tension between remembering and forgetting is not, of course, unique to Korea. From the Armenian Genocide to the Rwandan massacres, from the desaparecidos of Argentina to the victims of South Africa’s apartheid state, the question of how societies reckon with mass atrocity is among the most contested domains of both ethics and politics. Yet Jeju occupies a singular place in this

global reckoning. It is a case in which the transition from silence to acknowledgment was extraordinarily slow—stretching across five decades of democratic and semi-democratic governance—and yet ultimately, if imperfectly, achieved. The Jeju 4.3 Special Act of 2000 and the subsequent governmental apology by President Roh Moo-hyun in 2003 represent landmark moments in the global history of transitional justice. They also provide an unusually well-documented record of what is lost, and what may be partially recovered, when collective memory is first extinguished and then, haltingly, rekindled.

II. The Historical Contours of the Incident

To understand the ethics of forgetting in Jeju's case, one must first reckon with the magnitude of what was forgotten. The April Third Incident was precipitated by the uprising of the South Korean Workers' Party (SKWP) on Jeju Island against the U.S. Military Government and the nascent south Korean state, which the insurgents viewed as an illegitimate anti-communist client regime. What began as a politically motivated insurrection was met with a counter-insurgency operation of overwhelming, disproportionate brutality.

According to the 2003 findings of the Jeju 4.3 Incident Investigation Report—a document produced by the government-commissioned Truth Commission following the Special Act—between 14,000 and 30,000 people perished during the seven-year period of violence, with most estimates converging around 25,000 to 30,000 fatalities (Jeju 4.3 Research Institute, 2003). Given Jeju's population of approximately 300,000 at the time, this represents a death toll constituting roughly one-tenth of the entire island population. Entire mountain villages were razed. Over 70% of the island's villages were either burned or destroyed (Merrill, 1989). Approximately 39,285 homes were reported destroyed and an estimated 230 villages were annihilated (Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation, 2014).

The commission's report identified the south Korean state security forces and the Northwest Youth Corps (Seobuk Cheongnyeondan)—a paramilitary organisation of refugees from North Korea—as the primary perpetrators of civilian massacres, though it also documented killings carried out by the insurgents themselves. Crucially, the state's own culpability was unambiguously acknowledged: "The government bears a great responsibility for the massacre of innocent people in the name of anti-communist operations" (Jeju 4.3 Incident Investigation Report, 2003, p. 536). This acknowledgement, belated as it was, is without precedent in South Korean political history and marks an epistemological rupture of considerable ethical significance.

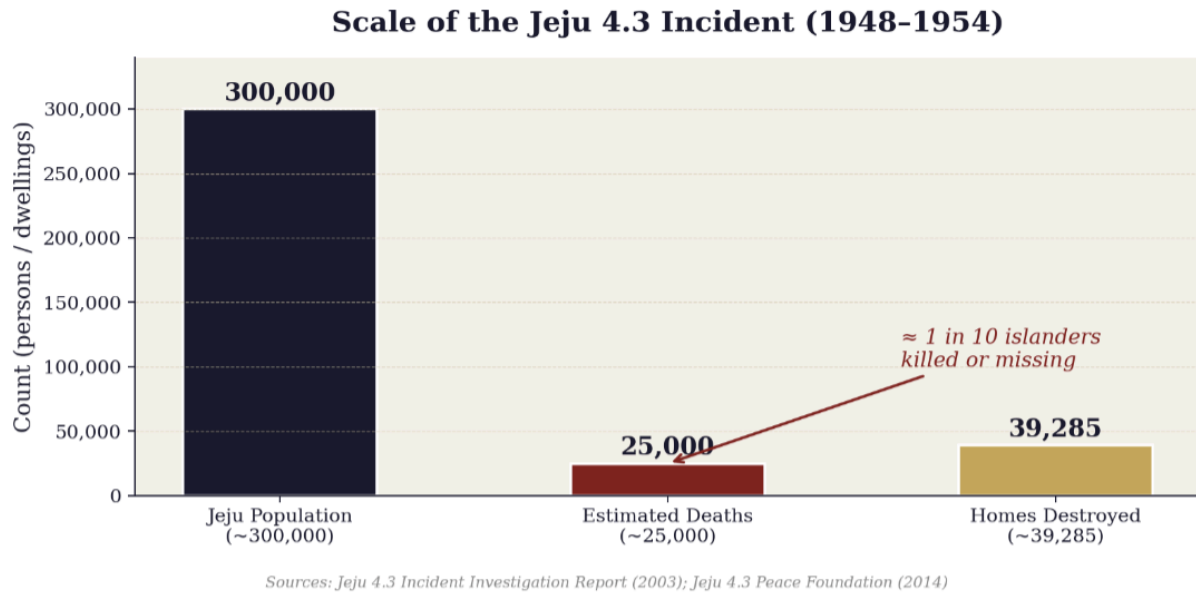


Figure 1: Scale of the Jeju 4.3 Incident (1948–1954). Source: Jeju 4.3 Incident Investigation Report (2003); Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation (2014).

III. The Mechanics of Institutionalised Forgetting

The suppression of Jeju’s memory was not accidental. It was systematic, deliberate, and enforced through law, ideology, and terror. Under the successive authoritarian governments of Syngman Rhee and then Park Chung-hee, any public discussion of the events of April Third was classified as proto-communist agitation. Survivors who spoke of the massacres were subject to surveillance, arrest, and in some documented cases, execution. The National Security Law, enacted in December 1948 in the direct aftermath of the uprising, provided the juridical infrastructure for this suppression, criminalising speech and assembly deemed sympathetic to communism with penalties extending to capital punishment (Kim, 2000).

The French historian Henry Rousso, writing of the Vichy syndrome in France—another case of prolonged collective denial—coined the concept of “amnesia as strategy” to describe the deliberate political instrumentalisation of forgetting (Rousso, 1991). In Jeju’s case, this strategic amnesia was particularly pronounced: survivors were compelled not merely to remain silent but to actively participate in the falsification of memory, lest they or their descendants be branded as communist sympathisers. The second-generation testimonies collected by the Jeju 4.3 Research Institute reveal a pervasive culture of intergenerational silence, in which grandparents refused to tell grandchildren the

fates of those who had disappeared, not out of indifference but out of a protective terror (Jeju 4.3 Research Institute, 2008).

This compelled silence is, ethically speaking, a form of secondary victimisation. Scholars of trauma studies have long established that the denial of narrative—the inability to bear witness, to name the dead, to speak the experience—constitutes a form of ongoing harm that may, in clinical terms, be as debilitating as the original trauma itself (Herman, 1992). When the state enforces this silence, the ethical weight of the forgetting is correspondingly intensified. It is no longer merely an absence of memory but an act of violence committed against the very capacity for memory.

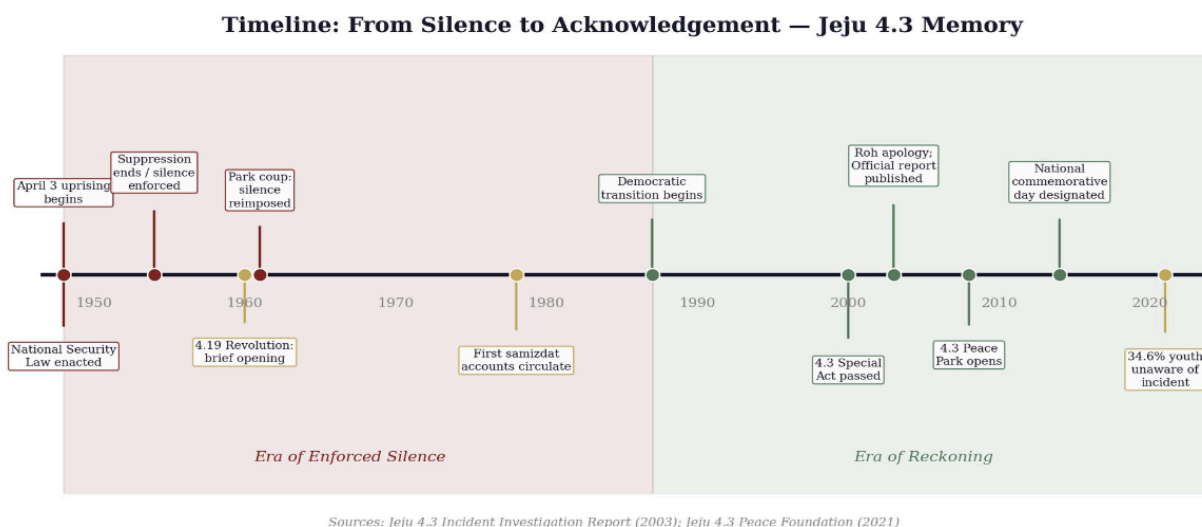


Figure 2: Timeline from Enforced Silence to Official Acknowledgement (1948–2021). Sources: Jeju 4.3 Incident Investigation Report (2003); Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation (2021).

IV. The Ethics of Memory: Philosophical Foundations

The philosophical literature on memory ethics has grown substantially since the 1990s, informed in large part by the proliferation of truth commissions, memorialisation projects, and demands for official apology across the post-Cold War world. Among the most influential frameworks is that of Aleida Assmann, whose distinction between “storage memory” (Speichergedächtnis) and “functional memory” (Funktionsgedächtnis) has proven particularly productive (Assmann, 2008). Storage memory is the archive: the passive repository of all that is preserved but not actively utilised in collective identity formation. Functional memory, by contrast, is the selective, narratively organised subset of the archive that a community actively employs in the construction of its self-understanding.

What makes the Jeju case ethically instructive is that the suppression of 4.3 operated at both levels simultaneously. The state not only prevented the archive from being formed—destroying documents, suppressing testimonies, forbidding scholarship—but also actively colonised functional memory by substituting an official narrative that cast the victims as communists deserving of their fate. This double operation is what distinguishes mere neglect from what the philosopher Margaret Urban Walker (2010) calls “moral repair” failure: the refusal to acknowledge wrongdoing in ways that would permit the wronged party’s moral standing to be restored.

Ricoeur’s concept of “just memory” (*mémoire juste*) is equally pertinent here. Writing against both the excesses of traumatic over-remembering (which he associated with the kind of identity politics that militarises memory) and the pathology of forgetting, Ricoeur argued for a form of memory that is oriented by the obligation of justice: one that remembers specifically in order to acknowledge the claims of the victim upon the living (Ricoeur, 2004, pp. 86–92). On this account, the ethical imperative to remember Jeju is not merely sentimental or historiographical: it is a demand grounded in the basic moral requirement to treat persons—including the dead—as ends in themselves rather than as instruments of political narrative.

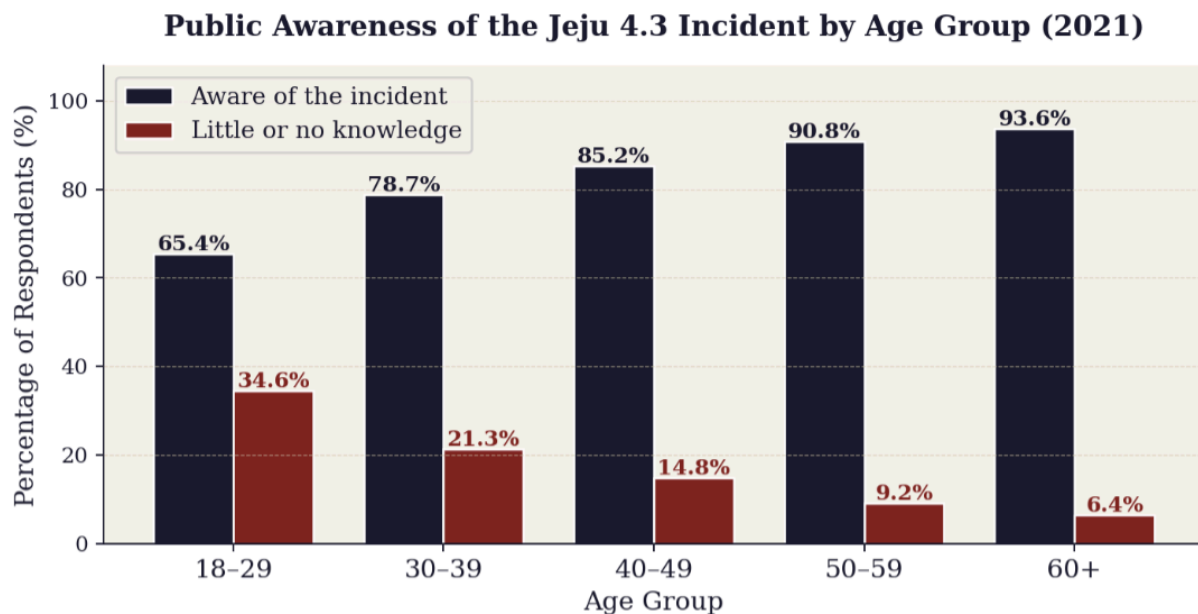
V. The Politics of Acknowledgement: Transitional Justice and Its Limits

The passage of the Jeju 4.3 Special Act in January 2000, followed by the publication of the official government investigation report in 2003, and President Roh Moo-hyun’s formal apology on April 3, 2003—the fifty-fifth anniversary of the uprising—represented a tectonic shift in South Korea’s politics of memory. The apology was, by any comparative standard, remarkable: a sitting head of state assuming institutional responsibility for atrocities committed by preceding governments. In this, South Korea joined a small cohort of states—including Germany, Argentina, and South Africa—that have sought formal reconciliation with the victims of state violence through official acknowledgement rather than continued erasure.

And yet the process has been neither linear nor uncontested. As recently as 2019, conservative political forces within South Korea sought to revise the 4.3 narrative, reintroducing language that framed the uprising primarily as a communist insurrection rather than as a civilian massacre. Such revisionism illustrates a pattern observed across multiple post-conflict societies: that the politics of memory is never settled but remains permanently vulnerable to the re-instrumentalisation of the past by competing political interests. According to survey data collected by the Jeju 4.3 Peace

Foundation in 2021, approximately 34.6% of South Koreans aged 18–29 reported having “little or no knowledge” of the Jeju incident, suggesting that even after two decades of official memorialisation, the transmission of historical consciousness across generations remains fragile (Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation, 2021).

This fragility is not incidental. It reflects a structural tension within all transitional justice processes between what Naomi Roht-Arriaza and Javier Mariezcurrena (2006) have called “the justice cascade”—the expanding global norm of accountability for mass atrocity—and the persistent counter-pressure of national political interests that resist full reckoning. The Jeju 4.3 Peace Park, opened in 2008, and the annual April Third memorial ceremony, designated a national commemorative day in 2014, represent institutional achievements of considerable significance. Yet the memorialisation infrastructure remains politically contingent: its funding, its curriculum integration in schools, and its official framing have all been subject to revision under successive administrations.



Source: Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation Survey (2021)

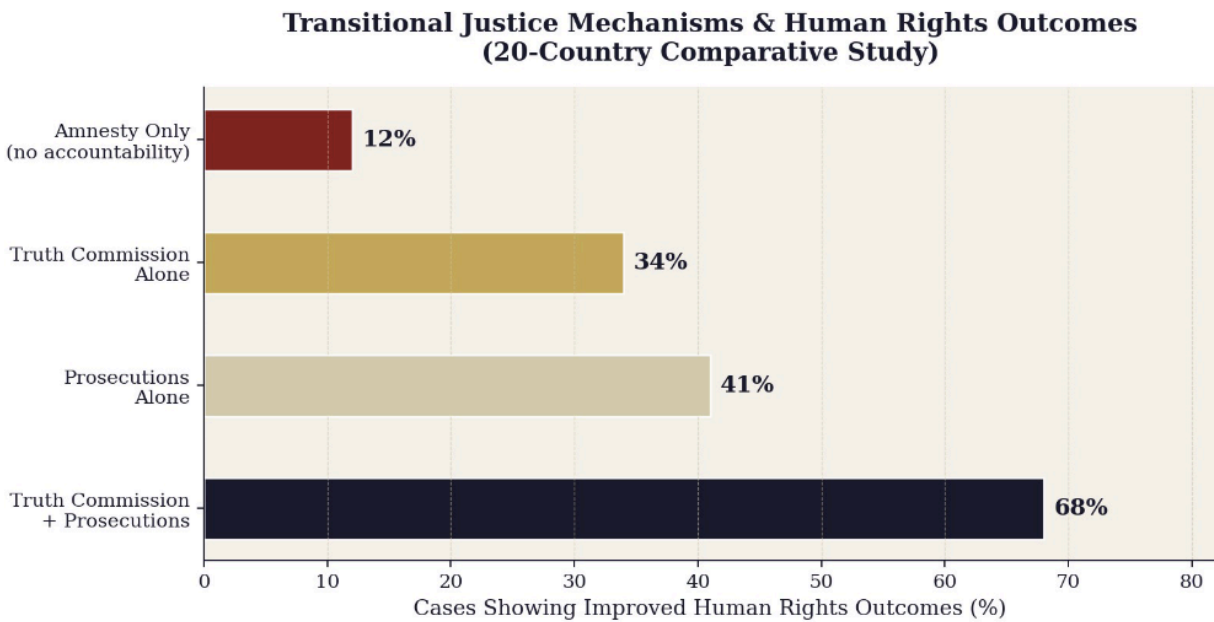
Figure 3: Public Awareness of the Jeju 4.3 Incident by Age Group, South Korea (2021). Source: Jeju 4.3 Peace Foundation Survey (2021).

VI. Against the Pragmatics of Forgetting: A Defence of Memory

It would be intellectually dishonest not to acknowledge that there exists a serious philosophical tradition that counsels, under certain circumstances, a pragmatics of forgetting. Ernest Renan's famous observation in "What Is a Nation?" (1882) that "every French citizen has to have forgotten the Night of Saint Bartholomew, or the massacres in the Midi in the thirteenth century" articulates the view that national cohesion may require the selective suppression of traumatic memory. More recently, scholars such as David Rieff (2016) have argued that "in praise of forgetting," certain historical grievances, if perpetually rehearsed, fuel cycles of resentment and violence rather than contributing to reconciliation.

These arguments, while not without merit in specific contexts, do not apply to the Jeju case—nor, it should be argued, to cases of state-perpetrated mass violence against civilian populations more generally. The pragmatics of forgetting presupposes that memory is already present and may be voluntarily relinquished in the service of a broader good. In Jeju's case, memory was never freely given. It was violently taken. To advocate for forgetting in such a context is not to counsel prudent restraint but to ratify the original crime. As the political philosopher Avishai Margalit argued in *The Ethics of Memory* (2002), while individuals may choose to forgive and even forget personal wrongs, the community bears a special obligation to maintain what he terms "shared memory" of moral atrocities, precisely because such atrocities are directed not merely against individuals but against humanity's shared moral order.

Moreover, the empirical evidence from comparative transitional justice studies suggests that societies which undertake meaningful processes of truth-telling and acknowledgement are, over time, more rather than less stable than those which do not. A comparative analysis of twenty post-conflict societies by Tricia Olsen, Leigh Payne, and Andrew Reiter (2010) found that truth commissions combined with prosecutions produced the most robust improvements in human rights outcomes, while amnesty without acknowledgement correlated with higher rates of subsequent political violence. Memory, on this evidence, is not merely an ethical obligation to the dead: it is a precondition for the sustainable peace of the living.



Source: Olsen, Payne & Reiter, Transitional Justice in Balance (2010)

Figure 4: Transitional Justice Mechanisms and Human Rights Outcomes across 20 Post-Conflict Societies. Source: Olsen, Payne & Reiter (2010).

VII. Conclusion: The Unfinished Work of Memory

The Jeju April Third Incident is, in the end, a story about the fragility and the necessity of truth. Approximately 14,000 to 30,000 people were killed in a period of seven years. For nearly half a century, their deaths were officially denied, their names erased from public record, their surviving families subjected to a regime of enforced silence that was itself a form of ongoing violence. The eventual acknowledgement—partial, contested, politically vulnerable—does not undo the harm. It cannot. The dead remain dead. The testimonies lost to a generation of fearful silence are irretrievable. What acknowledgement can do is something more modest but no less important: it can restore to the victims their moral standing as persons wronged, rather than enemies justly defeated. It can allow the living to grieve without shame. And it can, in Ricoeur's formulation, provide the foundation for a “just memory” oriented not by vengeance but by the recognition of shared humanity across the boundary of death.

The ethics of remembering, as illuminated by Jeju, is not the ethics of obsession or of grievance perpetually renewed. It is the ethics of witness: the refusal to allow the state's violence to complete itself by also erasing the record of its commission. In a world in which such violence continues—in which states still massacre civilians and then mobilise the apparatus of official forgetting to protect

themselves from accountability—the lesson of Jeju is not merely historical. It is a standing obligation, renewed each April Third, to insist that what happened shall not be unmade.

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